Should we pursue the acquisition of a European supply-chain competitor?

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Situation

Decide this quarter whether to stage European acquisitions or pursue one large competitor. The staged route defines the objective first, then funds bolt-ons and a network joint venture. A large deal waits until integration is proven.

European M&A reached USD746bn to early December 2025, 12% above full-year 2024 ([A&O Shearman](https://www.aoshearman.com/en/insights/global-ma-insights/transactional-activity-in-europe-gains-momentum-heading-into-2026)). Transport Intelligence counted 64 logistics transactions in September 2026. Dachser bought Drummond Logistics. GEODIS bought Deret ([Transport Intelligence](https://ti-insight.com/briefs/logistics-ma-in-september-2026-technology-and-infrastructure-deals-broaden-acquisition-strategies/)).

Hulett put 1H 2026 median multiples at 6.6x EV/EBITDA for private-equity deals and 7.4x for strategic deals ([Axia Growth](https://axiagrowth.com/resources/industries/transportation-logistics)). The source does not confirm a European split.

The European Commission published draft merger guidelines on 30 April 2026. They are not legally binding. Final adoption is expected around end-2026 or early 2027 ([Sullivan & Cromwell](https://www.sullcrom.com/insights/memo/2026/May/EU-Merger-Control-New-Draft-Merger-Guidelines)).

DSV announced its Schenker purchase in September 2024 and obtained all clearances on 15 April 2025. It raised about DKK 75bn, split evenly between equity and bonds. It guided to DKK 9.0bn annual synergies by end-2028 ([DSV](https://investor.dsv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/dsv-1154-dsv-completes-acqusition-schenker)). Trade press reported that road freight customer satisfaction declined because of disruption in Europe ([Trans.info](https://trans.info/en/dsv-lifts-guidance-as-schenker-boosts-results-but-european-road-integration-weighs-491528)).

No requester financials or target segment have been supplied.

Sources:

- Deal activity in Europe gains momentum heading into 2026 — https://www.aoshearman.com/en/insights/global-ma-insights/transactional-activity-in-europe-gains-momentum-heading-into-2026
- Logistics M&A in September 2026: technology and infrastructure deals broaden acquisition strategies — https://ti-insight.com/briefs/logistics-ma-in-september-2026-technology-and-infrastructure-deals-broaden-acquisition-strategies/
- Transportation & Logistics M&A: Buyers, Multiples — https://axiagrowth.com/resources/industries/transportation-logistics
- EU Commission Publishes Draft Merger Guidelines for Public Consultation — https://www.sullcrom.com/insights/memo/2026/May/EU-Merger-Control-New-Draft-Merger-Guidelines
- DSV, 1154 - DSV COMPLETES THE ACQUISITION OF SCHENKER — https://investor.dsv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/dsv-1154-dsv-completes-acqusition-schenker
- DSV lifts guidance as Schenker boosts results, but European road integration weighs — https://trans.info/en/dsv-lifts-guidance-as-schenker-boosts-results-but-european-road-integration-weighs-491528

Complication

Rivals are buying European logistics platforms at speed in 2026, so targets may disappear. Transport Intelligence counted 64 logistics transactions in September 2026 alone. Dachser and GEODIS are among the active buyers. Pre-emption risk is immediate.

Deal value is recovering too. European M&A reached USD746bn by early December 2025, 12% above full-year 2024. Price direction is unproven. The 2026 medians found show strategic buyers at 7.4x and private equity at 6.6x. They carry no European split. A second dataset shows 12.19x. Deal volume is not evidence of rising prices.

The rules are also moving. The Commission published draft merger guidelines on 30 April 2026. Final adoption is expected around end-2026 or early 2027. The text is not binding yet.

Integration is the sharper threat. DSV's European road integration after Schenker lowered customer satisfaction. Competitors used the deal as a commercial opportunity. Our own integration record is unknown.

A large competitor deal now bets on price, rules and execution at once. The board must decide whether to fix strategy and leverage first.

Sources:

- Logistics M&A in September 2026: technology and infrastructure deals broaden acquisition strategies — https://ti-insight.com/briefs/logistics-ma-in-september-2026-technology-and-infrastructure-deals-broaden-acquisition-strategies/
- Deal activity in Europe gains momentum heading into 2026 — https://www.aoshearman.com/en/insights/global-ma-insights/transactional-activity-in-europe-gains-momentum-heading-into-2026
- Transportation & Logistics M&A: Buyers, Multiples — https://axiagrowth.com/resources/industries/transportation-logistics
- EU Commission Publishes Draft Merger Guidelines for Public Consultation — https://www.sullcrom.com/insights/memo/2026/May/EU-Merger-Control-New-Draft-Merger-Guidelines
- DSV lifts guidance as Schenker boosts results, but European road integration weighs — https://trans.info/en/dsv-lifts-guidance-as-schenker-boosts-results-but-european-road-integration-weighs-491528
- DSV accelerates the integration of Schenker - TrasportoEuropa — https://www.trasportoeuropa.it/english/dsv-accelerates-the-integration-of-schenker/

Key Question

Should the board defer a large European competitor acquisition for smaller bolt-ons this quarter?

Answer

The board should fund smaller European bolt-ons now and defer any large competitor acquisition. Bolt-ons build integration capability step by step and avoid a single integration shock. A network joint venture adds coverage meanwhile.

McKinsey puts integration costs at 70–160% of run-rate synergies, averaging 120% ([McKinsey](https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/people-and-organizational-performance/our-insights/eight-basic-beliefs-about-capturing-value-in-a-merger)). One large deal carries that burden in a single integration. The board first confirms the strategic objective, segment and leverage headroom this quarter.

Sources:

- Eight basics for capturing deal value in mergers — https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/people-and-organizational-performance/our-insights/eight-basic-beliefs-about-capturing-value-in-a-merger

Supporting Arguments

Competitive European auctions will persist through 2026, so price discipline will decide deal value. European M&A reached USD746bn to early December 2025, 12% above full-year 2024 ([A&O Shearman](https://www.aoshearman.com/en/insights/global-ma-insights/transactional-activity-in-europe-gains-momentum-heading-into-2026)). Transport Intelligence counted 64 logistics deals in September 2026 ([Transport Intelligence](https://ti-insight.com/briefs/logistics-ma-in-september-2026-technology-and-infrastructure-deals-broaden-acquisition-strategies/)). Hulett's first-half 2026 medians were 6.6x EV/EBITDA for private equity and 7.4x for strategic buyers ([Axia Growth](https://axiagrowth.com/resources/industries/transportation-logistics)). That data is not Europe-specific. The board should fix a walk-away ceiling before talks and count only cost synergies.

EU merger control will probably clear a fragmented-market deal, with review risk persisting into 2027. The Commission found no competition concerns in DSV/DB Schenker ([JCtrans](https://m.jctrans.com/en/news/11776/)). That deal was very large, so it is no guarantee. The draft guidelines are not binding. Final adoption is expected around end-2026 or early 2027 ([Sullivan & Cromwell](https://www.sullcrom.com/insights/memo/2026/May/EU-Merger-Control-New-Draft-Merger-Guidelines)). The Foreign Subsidies Regulation adds a mandatory filing at €500m target EU turnover and €50m foreign support ([Wolters Kluwer](https://legalblogs.wolterskluwer.com/competition-blog/the-eu-fsr-decision-and-its-implications-for-middle-eastern-investors/)). An overlap analysis by national market must precede any bid.

Integration will decide whether value survives the three years after close. The company should stage its commitments accordingly. McKinsey reports integration costs of 70% to 160% of run-rate synergies, averaging 120% ([McKinsey](https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/people-and-organizational-performance/our-insights/eight-basic-beliefs-about-capturing-value-in-a-merger)). DSV guides to annual synergies of DKK 9.0bn at end-2028 ([DSV](https://investor.dsv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/dsv-1154-dsv-completes-acqusition-schenker)). Its European road integration also hurt customers, as satisfaction scores declined ([trans.info](https://trans.info/en/dsv-lifts-guidance-as-schenker-boosts-results-but-european-road-integration-weighs-491528)). Customer-loss risk therefore stays medium after mitigation. A revenue-attrition downside case belongs in the walk-away ceiling. A joint venture for coverage builds integration capability first. A larger competitor deal waits until integration and retention are proven.

Sources:

- Deal activity in Europe gains momentum heading into 2026 — https://www.aoshearman.com/en/insights/global-ma-insights/transactional-activity-in-europe-gains-momentum-heading-into-2026
- Logistics M&A in September 2026: technology and infrastructure deals broaden acquisition strategies — https://ti-insight.com/briefs/logistics-ma-in-september-2026-technology-and-infrastructure-deals-broaden-acquisition-strategies/
- Transportation & Logistics M&A: Buyers, Multiples — https://axiagrowth.com/resources/industries/transportation-logistics
- DSV Clears Major Hurdle in DB Schenker Acquisition as EU Approves Deal — https://m.jctrans.com/en/news/11776/
- EU Commission Publishes Draft Merger Guidelines for Public Consultation — https://www.sullcrom.com/insights/memo/2026/May/EU-Merger-Control-New-Draft-Merger-Guidelines
- The EU FSR Decision and Its Implications for Middle Eastern Investors — https://

legalblogs.wolterskluwer.com/competition-blog/the-eu-fsr-decision-and-its-implications-for-middle-eastern-investors/

- Eight basics for capturing deal value in mergers — https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/people-and-organizational-performance/our-insights/eight-basic-beliefs-about-capturing-value-in-a-merger
- DSV, 1154 - DSV COMPLETES THE ACQUISITION OF SCHENKER — https://investor.dsv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/dsv-1154-dsv-completes-acqusition-schenker
- DSV lifts guidance as Schenker boosts results, but European road integration weighs — https://trans.info/en/dsv-lifts-guidance-as-schenker-boosts-results-but-european-road-integration-weighs-491528

So What

Approve a 90-day screening mandate at the next board meeting; the CEO owns it. Inaction costs position: the market closed [64 logistics deals in September 2026 alone](https://ti-insight.com/briefs/logistics-ma-in-september-2026-technology-and-infrastructure-deals-broaden-acquisition-strategies/).

Screen bolt-on targets and a joint venture first. Defer any large competitor bid until integration capability is proven. The CFO prices DSV-type customer attrition and a leverage ceiling into the walk-away price before any bid.

Sources:

- Logistics M&A in September 2026: technology and infrastructure deals broaden acquisition strategies — https://ti-insight.com/briefs/logistics-ma-in-september-2026-technology-and-infrastructure-deals-broaden-acquisition-strategies/

Insufficiently sourced

This format's sourcing policy is strict. The 35 item(s) below did not meet it. They stayed in the analysis that produced this briefing; treat every statement that rests on them as unverified.

- **research item 1**: https://www.aoshearman.com/en/insights/global-ma-insights/transactional-activity-in-europe-gains-momentum-heading-into-2026 is not a trusted domain (host 'www.aoshearman.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **research item 2**: https://ti-insight.com/briefs/logistics-ma-in-september-2026-technology-and-infrastructure-deals-broaden-acquisition-strategies/ is not a trusted domain (host 'ti-insight.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **research item 3**: https://axiagrowth.com/resources/industries/transportation-logistics is not a trusted domain (host 'axiagrowth.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **research item 4**: https://www.sullcrom.com/insights/memo/2026/May/EU-Merger-Control-New-Draft-Merger-Guidelines is not a trusted domain (host 'www.sullcrom.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **research item 5**: https://m.jctrans.com/en/news/11776/ is not a trusted domain (host 'm.jctrans.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **research item 6**: https://investor.dsv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/dsv-1154-dsv-completes-acqusition-schenker is not a trusted domain (host 'investor.dsv.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **research item 7**: https://legalblogs.wolterskluwer.com/competition-blog/the-eu-fsr-decision-and-its-implications-for-middle-eastern-investors/ is not a trusted domain (host 'legalblogs.wolterskluwer.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **Research finding 9** — “No source was found on how works-council consultation and national employment law would affect the timing or synergy delivery of a cross-border European logistics acquisition.”: no source found (searched for: Evidence on works-council information and consultation requirements, national labour-law constraints on restructuring, and country-level FDI screening for European logistics acquisitions, including effects on timeline and synergy capture.).
- **Stakeholder Acquirer board and executive leadership (the requester's company)**: position not sourced (searched for: Public statements on the requester's European growth strategy or appetite for acquiring a supply-chain competitor. No company-specific information was supplied and none can be found in public sources.).
- **stakeholder item 2**: https://www.goodwinlaw.com/en/insights/publications/2026/05/alerts-practices-antc-european-commissions-draft-merger-guidelines is not a trusted domain (host 'www.goodwinlaw.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **stakeholder item 3**: https://www.cooley.com/news/insight/2026/2026-02-19-uk-merger-control-in-2026-what-to-expect is not a trusted domain (host 'www.cooley.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **stakeholder item 4**: https://ti-insight.com/briefs/logistics-ma-in-september-2026-technology-and-infrastructure-deals-broaden-acquisition-strategies/ is not a trusted domain (host 'ti-insight.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **Stakeholder Target company owners and management (sellers)**: position not sourced (searched for: Public statements on willingness to sell or deal preferences. No target has been identified, and the scoping excludes naming one.).
- **Stakeholder Works councils, European Works Council and employee representatives (target and acquirer)**: position not sourced (searched for: Documented stances of works councils, unions or the EWC on logistics consolidation. Searches returned only legal descriptions of

consultation rights, for example EWC consultation on cross-border mergers, and nothing on any stance toward a specific deal.).
- **Stakeholder Acquirer shareholders and financing providers (equity investors, lenders, bond investors)**: position not sourced (searched for: Investor or lender positions on the requester's potential acquisition. No company financials or investor communications were supplied.).
- **Stakeholder Key customers of the acquirer and the target**: position not sourced (searched for: Customer views on consolidation among European logistics providers. No customer-specific or segment-specific evidence was found, and the segment was not specified.).
- **risk item 1**: https://www.logisyn.com/news-resources-all/june-2026-acquisitions is not a trusted domain (host 'www.logisyn.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **risk item 2**: https://www.aranca.com/knowledge-library/articles/business-research/why-do-mergers-and-acquisitions-fail is not a trusted domain (host 'www.aranca.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **risk item 3**: https://ti-insight.com/briefs/logistics-ma-in-september-2026-technology-and-infrastructure-deals-broaden-acquisition-strategies/ is not a trusted domain (host 'ti-insight.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **Risk RISK-002** (impact evidence): not sourced (searched for: Quantified cost to an acquirer of losing a preferred logistics target to a rival, or the value of a pre-emption strategy. Results covered deal activity only.).
- **risk item 5**: https://www.mcdermottlaw.com/insights/a-new-era-for-eu-merger-control-key-takeaways-from-the-draft-guidelines/ is not a trusted domain (host 'www.mcdermottlaw.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **Risk RISK-003** (impact evidence): not sourced (searched for: Documented cost, delay or remedy burden of in-depth EU or national reviews of European logistics deals. Results covered the draft guidelines but no logistics remedy outcomes.).
- **risk item 7**: https://vlolawfirm.com/case-studies/works-council-consultation-europe is not a trusted domain (host 'vlolawfirm.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **risk item 8**: https://globallawexperts.com/how-to-respond-2/ is not a trusted domain (host 'globallawexperts.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **risk item 9**: https://www.gotara.com/cost-of-ma-failure/ is not a trusted domain (host 'www.gotara.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **risk item 10**: https://www.valoremreply.com/resources/insights/blog/why-delayed-integration-post-mergers-can-derail-your-investment/ is not a trusted domain (host 'www.valoremreply.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **risk item 11**: https://trans.info/en/dsv-lifts-guidance-as-schenker-boosts-results-but-european-road-integration-weighs-491528 is not a trusted domain (host 'trans.info' matches no reputation tier).
- **risk item 12**: https://www.trasportoeuropa.it/english/dsv-accelerates-the-integration-of-schenker/ is not a trusted domain (host 'www.trasportoeuropa.it' matches no reputation tier).
- **Risk RISK-007** (likelihood evidence): not sourced (searched for: The requester's balance sheet, leverage headroom and investor appetite. No company financials were supplied, so the likelihood cannot be benchmarked.).
- **risk item 14**: https://www.investing.com/news/company-news/dsv-q3-2025-slides-schenker-integration-boosts-results-amid-challenging-markets-93CH-4304032 is not a trusted domain (host 'www.investing.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **risk item 15**: https://theloadstar.com/dsv-says-schenker-can-deliver-as-integration-progresses-at-a-cost/ is not a trusted domain (host 'theloadstar.com' matches no reputation tier).
- **Risk RISK-008** (impact evidence): not sourced (searched for: Quantified effect of freight-cycle downturns on acquired logistics earnings or deal returns. Only company-level unit-profit data was found.).

- **risk item 17**: https://imaa-institute.org/publications/perspectives-on-merger-integration/ is not a trusted domain (host 'imaa-institute.org' matches no reputation tier).
- **Risk RISK-009** (impact evidence): not sourced (searched for: Quantified value lost from key-talent departures in logistics acquisitions. No logistics-specific source was returned.).
- **risk item 19**: https://acquisitionstars.com/ma-failure-rate is not a trusted domain (host 'acquisitionstars.com' matches no reputation tier).

Options

ID	Title	Recommendation	Time horizon
OPT-A	Acquisition with board approval gates before due diligence	recommended	short-term
OPT-B	Immediate pre-emptive bid for the preferred target	not-recommended	immediate
OPT-C	Joint venture or minority stake with an option to increase it	acceptable	short-term
OPT-D	Organic European expansion without an acquisition	not-recommended	medium-term

Risks

ID	Category	Likelihood	Impact	Timeframe
RISK-001	financial	high	major	short-term
RISK-002	strategic	high	moderate	immediate
RISK-003	regulatory	medium	major	medium-term
RISK-004	human-capital	high	moderate	medium-term
RISK-005	financial	medium	major	medium-term
RISK-006	operational	medium	major	short-term
RISK-007	financial	medium	major	short-term
RISK-008	financial	medium	moderate	short-term
RISK-009	human-capital	medium	moderate	short-term
RISK-010	strategic	medium	major	immediate

Stakeholders

Name	Position	Power	Priority
Acquirer board and executive leadership	unknown	high	critical
European Commission (DG COMP, under EVP Teresa Ribera)	neutral	high	critical
National competition authorities (Member State authorities, Switzerland, Norway)	neutral	high	important
Competing acquirers (strategic logistics groups such as DSV, Kuehne+Nagel, DHL, Dachser, GEODIS and private equity)	resistant	high	important
Target company owners and management	unknown	high	critical
Target employees, works councils, trade unions and European Works Council	unknown	medium	important
Acquirer shareholders and financing providers	unknown	high	important
Key customers of the target and acquirer, lenders, bond investors)	unknown	medium	important

Adversarial Critique

Robustness: medium
Critiques: 7 (critical=0, material=3, minor=4)
Revision needed: yes

Steelmanned alternative:
Take a strategy-first, programmatic route. Over the next quarter the board defines the strategic objective and confirms the segment and leverage headroom. It then funds a series of smaller bolt-on acquisitions in fragmented European segments, where strategic multiples have recently softened, alongside a network JV for coverage. This builds integration capability step by step and avoids a single DSV-style integration shock. A larger competitor acquisition is deferred until the company has proven it can integrate and retain customers.

CRIT-001 — internal-contradiction (material)

Steelmanned position:
The Complication says paid multiples are rising and cites the 7.4x strategic versus 6.6x PE medians as evidence of deal heat. Hulett's own report shows the opposite trend. The strategic median fell from 12.7x to 7.4x year on year, and was only 5.0x in Q1 2026, while the PE median rose. Those figures describe a softening, thinly reported strategic market, not an overheated one. The brief also relies on the Logisyn line about rising multiples, which is a single specialist-advisory snippet. That reliance mixes up 'more deals' with 'higher prices'. RISK-001's high likelihood rating, the 'narrow window' framing and the urgency in So What all rest on this premise. The premise is contradicted by the brief's own data source.

Implication if true:
If strategic multiples are falling, the overpayment risk is lower and the cost of waiting is smaller than the brief claims. The board would then have room to define the strategic objective first instead of starting target screening at the next meeting.

Suggested revision:
Restate the multiples trend correctly as strategic medians falling from 12.7x to 7.4x on thin disclosure, downgrade RISK-001 likelihood to medium unless Europe- and segment-specific comparables show otherwise, and remove 'paid multiples are rising' from the Complication.

Counter-evidence:
Transportation & Logistics M&A Update Q2 2026 — https://rlhulett.com/app/uploads/2026/08/Transportation-Logistics-MA-Update-Q2-2026.pdf

CRIT-002 — temporal-blind-spot (minor)

Steelmanned position:
The brief uses DSV/Schenker as its main reassuring precedent, citing clean clearance, a balanced financing mix and DKK 9bn of synergies. It also cites 2025 one-off integration costs of only DKK 2.0–2.5bn. That snapshot is out of date. DSV now guides to about DKK 11bn of total transaction and integration costs, which is above the DKK 9bn run-rate synergy target. Its Q3 2026 results report negative volumes, operational problems in Europe and remaining synergies slipping into 2027. As of November 2026, the precedent is a warning about integration rather than evidence that the hurdles are 'manageable'.

Implication if true:
The supporting argument that hurdles are manageable is weaker than presented. The synergy-timing assumptions in the 50% payaway cap should include delays like DSV's.

Suggested revision:
Update finding 5 and the Supporting Arguments with DSV's latest guidance (about DKK 11bn total integration costs, synergies delayed into 2027, Q3 2026 volume losses) and present the precedent as mixed rather than favourable.

Counter-evidence:
Q3 2026 RESULTS DSV A/S Investor presentation — https://investor.dsv.com/static-files/adddb7f6-38cf-4f55-bdb7-3f04de31cb51

CRIT-003 — risk-underestimated (material)

Steelmanned position:
RISK-006 is rated low after mitigation, on the strength of account mapping, executive sponsors and staged cutovers. DSV is arguably Europe's most experienced serial logistics integrator and used similar playbooks. Even so, analysts now say it underestimated customer losses and volume declines in European road freight, and its shares fell about 28% in 2026. If a best-in-class integrator could not contain customer attrition, a requester with unknown cross-border integration experience has no basis for a low residual rating. Rivals poaching accounts during integration is also a structural risk, and service-continuity commitments cannot remove it.

Implication if true:
Revenue attrition during integration should be priced into the walk-away ceiling, not treated as a mitigated tail risk. That would lower the maximum justifiable price and make the joint-venture fallback (OPT-C) relatively more attractive.

Suggested revision:
Raise RISK-006 residual risk to medium and add an explicit revenue-attrition haircut (for example, a downside case based on DSV-type volume loss in the integrated region) to the valuation-ceiling test in OPT-A.

Counter-evidence:
DSV Faces Customer Retention Crisis as Analyst Slashes Price Target by 24% — https://breakbulk.news/dsv-faces-customer-retention-crisis-as-analyst-slashes-price-target-by-24/

CRIT-004 — hidden-assumption (material)

Steelmanned position:
OPT-A quietly assumes the answer is one sizeable competitor acquisition, gated or not. The scoping question asked whether acquisition beats the alternatives. The option set never considers a programmatic route: several smaller bolt-ons in Europe's fragmented logistics segments. McKinsey's long-running research finds that infrequent large deals tend to hurt value creation and that large-deal strategies are roughly a coin flip. Programmatic acquirers outperform both large-deal and organic strategies. The requester's M&A experience is unknown, so a single large integration is exactly the profile that research flags as weakest.

Implication if true:
The recommended option may be the wrong kind of acquisition strategy, not just the wrong pace. A programmatic bolt-on programme could capture most of the scale benefit with less integration, regulatory and financing risk.

Suggested revision:
Add a programmatic bolt-on option to the options set and require the RISK-010 strategic-objective statement to compare it against a single large acquisition using the same return metrics.

Counter-evidence:
McKinsey Says Multiple, Smaller Deals Work Best - Global Finance Magazine — https://

gfmag.com/features/mckinsey-says-multiple-smaller-deals-work-best/

CRIT-005 — overconfidence (minor)

Steelmanned position:
The Complication says rivals 'will pre-empt any unscreened target', and So What says delay hands targets to rivals. RISK-002's impact evidence, however, is marked SOURCE_MISSING. The brief's own DSV/Schenker finding says clearance came because European logistics markets are fragmented. Sector reports describe road haulage as dominated by small and medium-sized operators. In a fragmented market, losing one target is rarely decisive because substitutes exist, so the urgency framing is asserted rather than shown.

Implication if true:
The cost of a few months' delay to firm up strategy and financing is likely small. This weakens the case for the CEO opening talks with owners within 60 days.

Suggested revision:
Replace 'will pre-empt any unscreened target' with a conditional statement tied to the confirmed segment's concentration, and note that pre-emption cost is unquantified.

Counter-evidence:
European freight: Weak demand and volatility become the "new normal" in 2026 — https://www.rha.uk.net/news/news/detail/european-freight-weak-demand-and-volatility-become-the-new-normal-in-2026

CRIT-006 — temporal-blind-spot (minor)

Steelmanned position:
RISK-008 is rated low after mitigation, using through-the-cycle EBITDA based on a five-year average. A five-year look-back from 2026 includes the 2021–22 freight boom, which would inflate the 'normalised' earnings base. Meanwhile, 2026 European road volumes between major economies are falling year on year. Rate increases are being driven by fuel and toll costs rather than demand, which may compress margins instead of supporting them. The mitigation could therefore embed peak-cycle earnings into the price.

Implication if true:
The valuation ceiling could be set too high if through-the-cycle EBITDA includes boom years. This would also weaken the leverage stress test.

Suggested revision:
Specify that normalised EBITDA excludes or adjusts the 2021–22 freight boom, and raise RISK-008 residual risk to medium until segment-specific demand forecasts are available.

Counter-evidence:
General increase in road freight rates in Europe in Q2 2026 — https://market-insights.upply.com/en/general-increase-in-road-freight-rates-in-europe-in-q2-2026

CRIT-007 — internal-contradiction (minor)

Steelmanned position:
OPT-A calls itself fully reversible until a binding offer is made, yet it has the CEO talking to target owners within 60 days. Negotiation research finds that escalation of commitment typically occurs in M&A, and that cultivating a credible alternative is the main defence against it. OPT-A's alternative is a JV with a counterparty that is named but not yet identified, and which the brief admits offers far smaller synergies. A weak fallback, together with CEO-level engagement before the tests pass, undermines the walk-away discipline the option depends on.

Implication if true:
Reversibility in practice is lower than claimed, so the price ceiling may give way under deal momentum. The gates need institutional safeguards, not just written thresholds.

Suggested revision:
Have a board member or committee independent of the deal team own the go/no-go tests, and require the JV fallback counterparty to be identified and sounded out before CEO talks with target owners begin.

Counter-evidence:
Power in Negotiation: Examples of Being Overly Committed to the Deal — https://www.pon.harvard.edu/daily/dealmaking-daily/dealmaking-are-you-overly-committed-to-the-deal

Appendix A — Findings

Finding 1

Claim:
European M&A is rebounding in value faster than in deal count, and sell-side auction activity is returning, which points to competitive bidding for attractive targets.

Evidence:
A&O Shearman reports European M&A of USD746bn to early December 2025, 12% above the full-year 2024 total. It also reports more structured sell-side processes and vendor due diligence. BCG's 2026 review says value has recovered more quickly than overall activity, and that European dealmaker sentiment is strong.

Source:
Deal activity in Europe gains momentum heading into 2026 — https://www.aoshearman.com/en/insights/global-ma-insights/transactional-activity-in-europe-gains-momentum-heading-into-2026

Finding 2

Claim:
Logistics and supply-chain consolidation in Europe is active in 2026, with strategic acquirers and private equity buying regional and specialist platforms. A rival could therefore move on the same target first.

Evidence:
Transport Intelligence counted 64 logistics transactions in September 2026 across freight forwarding, contract logistics, parcels, warehousing and technology. Examples include Dachser buying Drummond Logistics in the UK and GEODIS buying Deret. The July 2026 brief describes CEVA's Colis Privé building a pan-European last-mile platform through the Paack deal.

Source:
Logistics M&A in September 2026: technology and infrastructure deals broaden acquisition strategies — https://ti-insight.com/briefs/logistics-ma-in-september-2026-technology-and-infrastructure-deals-broaden-acquisition-strategies/

Finding 3

Claim:
Reported 2026 logistics deal multiples show strategic buyers paying more than private-equity buyers, which sets a price benchmark. The data is not specific to Europe, so it is a rough guide only.

Evidence:
Axia Growth cites Hulett's first-half 2026 medians of 6.6x EV/EBITDA for PE deals and 7.4x for strategic deals, with asset-light logistics valued above asset-based truckload. The same page cites a separate dataset with higher medians (12.19x), so multiples vary widely by segment and source. The page does not confirm a geographic split.

Source:
Transportation & Logistics M&A: Buyers, Multiples — https://axiagrowth.com/resources/industries/transportation-logistics

Finding 4

Claim:
EU merger-control policy is being revised: draft guidelines published on 30 April 2026 add a

'theory of benefit' and a more favourable view of scale, but also widen the grounds for intervention.

Evidence:
Sullivan & Cromwell describes the draft as one of the most significant overhauls of EU merger control in over two decades. It says the guidelines are not legally binding and leave the underlying law unchanged, with final adoption expected around end-2026 or early 2027. Macfarlanes notes that analysis is becoming more complex and open-ended, which may create more grounds for intervention. Another law-firm summary says the draft adds labour markets as a standalone parameter of competitive assessment.

Source:
EU Commission Publishes Draft Merger Guidelines for Public Consultation — https://www.sullcrom.com/insights/memo/2026/May/EU-Merger-Control-New-Draft-Merger-Guidelines

Finding 5

Claim:
A large European logistics deal, DSV/DB Schenker, was cleared by the European Commission without competition concerns because the relevant markets are fragmented. It took about seven months from announcement to closing.

Evidence:
The Commission examined road, air and ocean freight forwarding and contract logistics in several national EEA markets and found no competition concerns. Reporting values the deal at €14.3bn, with the announcement in September 2024. DSV's release says all regulatory clearances were obtained on 15 April 2025, and the deal completed shortly afterwards. This is a precedent for a very large deal and not a guarantee for a smaller or more concentrated one.

Source:
DSV Clears Major Hurdle in DB Schenker Acquisition as EU Approves Deal — https://m.jctrans.com/en/news/11776/

Finding 6

Claim:
In the DSV/Schenker precedent, the acquirer funded the deal about half by equity and half by bonds. It guided to synergies of about DKK 9bn a year by end-2028 and one-off integration costs of DKK 2.0–2.5bn in 2025.

Evidence:
DSV's completion announcement says it raised about DKK 75bn (EUR 10bn) through an evenly split mix of equity and bond issuance. It estimated annual synergies of about DKK 9.0bn by end-2028 from consolidating operations, facilities, back-office, finance and IT. It expected limited P&L benefit from synergies in 2025.

Source:
DSV, 1154 - DSV COMPLETES THE ACQUISITION OF SCHENKER — https://investor.dsv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/dsv-1154-dsv-completes-acqusition-schenker

Finding 7

Claim:
Beyond EU merger control, the Foreign Subsidies Regulation can require a separate notification and standstill if the target has at least €500m of EU turnover and the buyer group has received at least €50m of foreign financial contributions.

Evidence:

Wolters Kluwer's summary sets out the two thresholds, which are mandatory for qualifying deals. Norton Rose Fulbright describes a 25-working-day first review followed by a 90-working-day in-depth review. The FSR process runs in parallel with EU merger control but is handled by a different case team. The €50m test applies only if the buyer has non-EU state financial contributions.

Source:
The EU FSR Decision and Its Implications for Middle Eastern Investors — https://legalblogs.wolterskluwer.com/competition-blog/the-eu-fsr-decision-and-its-implications-for-middle-eastern-investors/

Finding 8

Claim:
McKinsey research indicates that one-off integration costs commonly absorb a large share of synergy value, and that cost synergies are delivered faster and more reliably than revenue synergies.

Evidence:
McKinsey's 'Eight basics' piece reports that integration costs range from 70% to 160% of run-rate synergies and average 120%. It also says cost synergies deliver faster and more reliably than revenue synergies, and that analysts are skeptical of revenue synergies. The article is dated, so the figures need testing against current logistics deals.

Source:
Eight basics for capturing deal value in mergers — https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/people-and-organizational-performance/our-insights/eight-basic-beliefs-about-capturing-value-in-a-merger

Finding 9

Claim:
No source was found on how works-council consultation and national employment law would affect the timing or synergy delivery of a cross-border European logistics acquisition.

Evidence:
The searches covered merger control, the Foreign Subsidies Regulation, deal activity and synergy benchmarks. They returned nothing on works-council, labour-consultation timelines or country-level FDI screening for logistics. Of the sources found, only the draft merger-guidelines coverage mentions labour considerations, and that is in the competition-assessment context.

Source:
SOURCE_MISSING — searched for: Evidence on works-council information and consultation requirements, national labour-law constraints on restructuring, and country-level FDI screening for European logistics acquisitions, including effects on timeline and synergy capture.

Appendix B — Stakeholders

Name	Category	Position	Power	Priority
Acquirer board and executive leadership	decision-maker	unknown	high	critical
European Commission (DG Competition, Teresa Ribera)	gatekeeper	neutral	high	critical
Lucrecia Pérez Olmo (CPMP, under EVP Teresa Ribera)	gatekeeper	neutral	high	important
Competing acquirers	influencer	resistant	high	important
Target company leadership	gatekeeper	unknown	high	critical
National competition authorities (Member State agencies such as Bundeskartellamt, Autorité de la concurrence, CNMC, plus the UK CMA)	gatekeeper	unknown	high	important
Employee representatives and trade unions (works councils, SE/SCE bodies, and union officials at both the acquirer and the target)	affected-party	unknown	medium	important
Key customers of the acquirer and the target	affected-party	unknown	medium	important
Shareholders and financiers (the acquirer's equity investors, lenders, bond investors)	gatekeeper	unknown	high	important

Appendix C — Risk Register

ID	Category	Likelihood	Impact	Timeframe
RISK-001	financial	high	major	short-term
RISK-002	strategic	high	moderate	immediate
RISK-003	regulatory	medium	major	medium-term
RISK-004	human-capital	high	moderate	medium-term
RISK-005	financial	medium	major	medium-term
RISK-006	operational	medium	major	short-term
RISK-007	financial	medium	major	short-term
RISK-008	financial	medium	moderate	short-term
RISK-009	human-capital	medium	moderate	short-term
RISK-010	strategic	medium	major	immediate

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Sourcing Report

Policy: strict
Total items: 44
OK: 9 · stale: 0 · untrusted: 24 · duplicated: 0 · missing: 11

Warnings:

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- [stakeholder] 'Acquirer board and executive leadership (the requester's company)' SOURCE_MISSING — Public statements on the requester's European growth strategy or appetite for acquiring a supply-chain competitor. No company-specific information was supplied and none can be found in public sources.
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- [stakeholder] 'Works councils, European Works Council and employee representatives (target and acquirer)' SOURCE_MISSING — Documented stances of works councils, unions or

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- [stakeholder] 'Acquirer shareholders and financing providers (equity investors, lenders, bond investors)' SOURCE_MISSING — Investor or lender positions on the requester's potential acquisition. No company financials or investor communications were supplied.
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